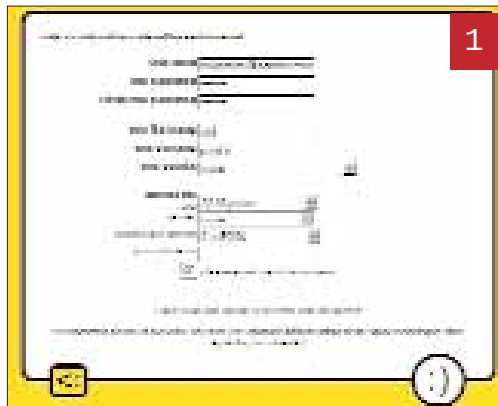


MTNSMS—Swift and Simple

MTNSMS, one of the foremost Web sites offering Web to mobile SMS services, is very simple to use. Log on to www.mtnsms.com and register.

Click on the join us button for the registration form.



In the registration form, fill in details such as your e-mail ID and personal information (see Fig 1); the mobile number field can be left empty. Clicking on the smiley button ensures that your confirmation code is mailed to your e-mail address, on receiving which you can start firing off your SMS messages.

Sending an SMS using MTNSMS is very simple (see Fig 2). Select the smsxpress link at the bottom of the page if you're in a hurry. Type the mobile number to which you want to send an SMS message in the mobile text box.

Ensure that the number is in the international format. You can convert Indian cellular numbers to this format by adding +91 before the number. For example, if the mobile number is 982017XXXX, in the international format it becomes +91982017XXXX.

Enter the message in the text box. Take care that the message does not exceed 160 characters—the counter will help you while doing this. Press the smiley and your SMS is sent.

Tracking your e-mail can be done using the track it here link in the page that comes next (see Fig 3).



You can see all the messages you send as well as the messages that you forward to other numbers in your message outbox (see Fig 4).

MSN Mobile', which will take you to the MSN Mobile Alert Settings page. Select the Add button next to Instant Messages, which will take you to the Instant Message Alerts page. Select the 'User & Device information' link to fill in your mobile number and other information, and

voila! Your friends and colleagues can now send messages to your mobile using MSN Messenger. MSN Messenger also allows you to send news, sports updates, etc. to a mobile phone for free.

Sending SMS with ICQ is really easy. All you need to do is click on the ICQ SMS icon below the ICQ tool bar. ICQ offers three options for sending SMS to your friends—via ICQ, Web, or e-mail. Select the preferred mode and start sending out your messages.

More than just SMS

There are free Web services on the Internet that offer news, sports updates, free icons, logos, and even horoscopes (see box, 'Operation of SMS Web Services'). And, of course, SMS chat. You also have free Web services that enable you to download ring tones (yes, you can get the theme of *Mission Impossible* as your ring tone to replace that monotonous beep).

For free ring tones, logos, horoscopes, etc., there are several sites such as www.texer.com, www.boltblue.com, and www.yourmobile.com, although some of these sites require you to register. You need to have an Internet-enabled cell phone for downloading ring tones directly. It's also possible to download the tone directly to your PC and transfer it via the infrared port of your PC to the cell phone. In order to do this, though, both your cell phone and PC should have infrared ports. So are you ready to get those services going?

The hidden thorns

Other than getting addicted to SMS (and it is highly addictive!), there are some other points to be considered. A major limitation is that SMS allows only a maximum of 160 characters in a message, and sometimes even less. If a message is longer than 160 characters, it is sent as multiple messages, which might involve a loss in transit.

Whenever you use a Web site to send an SMS, you essentially provide the site with your cell phone number. This could make you a target for spam.

Cellular phones provide advertisers an opportunity to contact people with location- and user-sensitive advertisements. With wireless Internet becoming increasingly popular, advertising on mobile devices is going to become widespread two or three years down the line and you may well be bombarded with advertisements on everything under the sun.

This is a worst-case scenario, though, and there's no need to get paranoid now. Most of these advertisements are likely to be of the 'opt-in' type, which means the user will be offered the option of receiving or rejecting them. No advertiser would want to have a user filing a case against him for spamming. So set your worries aside and get onto the SMS bandwagon. ■